01

CONCRETE, HONEST, UNFORGIVING

THE CLAIM

minimalist construction showcasing the bare building materials and structural elements over decorative design



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ACTIVE 1950s — EARLY 1980s · INTERNATIONAL

1950: a name for a house in Kåbo

02

1950

THE FIRST USE

The word arrived before the concrete. The Swedish architect Hans Asplund coined the term *nybrutalism* — new brutalism — to describe Villa Göth, a modern brick home in Uppsala.

The house was designed in January 1950 by **Bengt Edman** and **Lennart Holm**, contemporaries of Asplund. Nothing about it was monumental.

What it showed was the "as found" approach that would later sit at the core of brutalism: the building was allowed to say what it was made of, and no finish was added to soften the answer.

Villa Göth was listed as historically significant by the Uppsala county board on **3 March 1995** — the house that named the movement outlived most of the towers built in its name.

01	visible I-beams over the windows
02	exposed brick, inside and out
03	poured concrete keeping the tongue-and-groove pattern of its forms

Then it spread like wildfire

03

1950 — English architects visiting Sweden — Michael Ventris, Oliver Cox, Graeme Shankland — carry the term home, where it "spread like wildfire".

1953 — Alison Smithson puts **"new brutalism"** in print for the first time, describing the unbuilt Soho house in *Architectural Design*.

1954 — Hunstanton School completes in Norfolk: the **first finished building in the world** its own architects called "new brutalist".

1955 — The Sugden House completes in Watford. Hunstanton was likely inspired by Mies van der Rohe's 1946 Alumni Memorial Hall in Chicago.

> It is our intention in this building to have the structure exposed entirely, without interior finishes wherever practicable.
>
> — ALISON SMITHSON, 1953

Raw concrete, raw art

04

Reyner Banham, British architectural historian, used "new brutalism" to identify both an ethic and an aesthetic in his **1955 essay** *The New Brutalism* .

He named Hunstanton and the Soho house as "the reference by which The New Brutalism in architecture may be defined".

He expanded the argument in his 1966 book *The New Brutalism: Ethic or Aesthetic?*

THE CRITIC NAMES THE MATERIAL

béton brut

RAW CONCRETE

art brut

RAW ART

> "if there is one single verbal formula that has made the concept of Brutalism admissible in most of the world's Western languages, it is that Le Corbusier himself described that concrete work as 'béton-brut'"
>
> — REYNER BANHAM, 1966

"An ethic, not an aesthetic"

05

New brutalism was never only a style. It was a philosophical approach to design — a striving to create simple, honest, functional buildings that accommodate their purpose, inhabitants and location, a strict modernist language set against the retrospective nostalgia of much 1940s architecture.

Peter Smithson held that the core of brutalism was a reverence for materials, expressed honestly: "Brutalism is not concerned with the material as such but rather **the quality of material**", and "the seeing of materials for what they were: the woodness of the wood; the sandiness of sand".

John Voelcker said the new brutalism "cannot be understood through stylistic analysis, although some day a comprehensible style might emerge" — supporting the Smithsons' description of the movement as **an ethic, not an aesthetic**.

BANHAM'S THREE TERMS

1 formal legibility of plan

2 clear exhibition of structure

3 valuation of materials for their inherent qualities "as found"

an ethic, not an aesthetic

Banham also required the aesthetic "image" — the coherence of the building as a visual entity.

The grain of the formwork stays in the wall

06

CONCRETE BRICK GLASS STEEL TIMBER ROUGH-HEWN STONE GABIONS

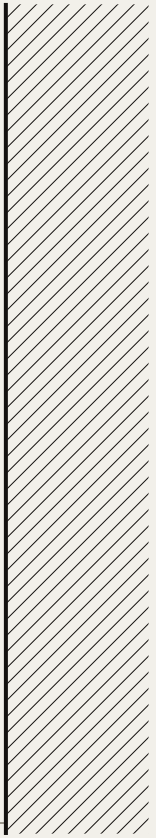
Raw concrete is often used because of its low cost, and then left to reveal the basic nature of its construction — rough surfaces carrying the wood **"shuttering"** pattern produced when the forms were cast in situ.

The style commonly uses exposed, unpainted concrete or brick, angular geometric shapes and a predominantly monochrome colour palette; steel, timber and glass also feature.

Examples are frequently massive in character even when not large, and challenge traditional notions of what a building should look like, with focus given to interior spaces as much as exterior.

Buildings are constructed with recurring modular elements representing specific functional zones, distinctly articulated and grouped into a unified whole.

Emphasis falls on graphic expression in the external elevations and in the whole-site plan, in regard to the main functions and people-flows of the building.



A façade that admits what it is doing

07

A common theme is the exposure of the building's inner workings — structure, services and human use — on the exterior.

EXAMPLE ONE · BOSTON

Boston City Hall, designed in 1962: the strikingly different and projected portions of the building indicate the special nature of the rooms behind those walls, such as the mayor's office or the city council chambers.

> Hunstanton School put the facility's water tank — normally a hidden service feature — in a prominent, visible tower. Its water and electric utilities were delivered via readily visible pipes and conduits rather than hidden in the walls.



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Concrete was the point, not the compromise

08

Brutalism as an architectural philosophy was often associated with a socialist utopian ideology, supported by its designers and especially by Alison and Peter Smithson near the height of the style. Their work sought to connect architecture with what they saw as the realities of modern life.

Among their early contributions were "streets in the sky", in which traffic and pedestrian circulation were rigorously separated — a theme popular in the 1960s. In Britain the style featured in **utilitarian, low-cost social housing** influenced by socialist principles, and spread from there to other regions.

In Czechoslovakia it was presented as an attempt at a "national" but also "modern socialist" style; such prefabricated socialist-era buildings are called *panelaky* .

TRADITIONAL STYLES BELONGED TO THE BOURGEOISIE —

concrete emphasised equality

MID-1960s TO LATE 1980s

- BULGARIA
- CZECHOSLOVAKIA
- EAST GERMANY
- USSR
- YUGOSLAVIA

Brick brutalism, or "brickalism", is the sub-genre where brick dominates instead of concrete — from the Smithsons' Soho house (1952) to Colin St John Wilson's British Library (1982–1998).

Eight countries, one language of concrete

09

COUNTRY	ARCHITECTS AND THE WORKS THE SOURCE NAMES
UNITED KINGDOM	
UNITED STATES	
AUSTRALIA	
CANADA	
ARGENTINA	
SERBIA	
VIETNAM	
BOSNIA AND HERZEGOVINA	

The universities built them first, and biggest

10

BRITAIN, EARLY

The 'beehives' at St John's College, Oxford (Michael Powers, Architects' Co-Partnership, 1958–60).

The 1959 architecture department extension at Cambridge under Leslie Martin, by Colin St John Wilson and Alex Hardy with student participation — it inspired the Grade II listed University Centre.

Stirling's Red Trilogy: Leicester Engineering with James Gowan (1959–63), often called Britain's first postmodern building; the Grade II* History Faculty, Cambridge (1964–67); the Florey Building, Oxford (1966–71).

THE NEW UNIVERSITIES

Basil Spence's Grade I Falmer House at Sussex (1960–62), a "meeting of Arts and Crafts with modernism" — hand-made bricks and colonnades of board-marked concrete arches inspired by the Colosseum.

Denys Lasdun's 'ziggurats' at UEA (1968): six linked halls in Norfolk Terrace, four in Suffolk Terrace, with the library and teaching wall between them.

Ove Arup's Grade I Kingsgate Bridge at Durham (1963) and Dunelm House (1964–66), saved from demolition in 2021 after a five-year campaign.

AMERICA AND BEYOND

Paul Rudolph's Art and Architecture Building at Yale (1963), where as department chair he was both client and architect. His 1964 UMass Dartmouth is a rare entire campus in the style.

William Pereira's Geisel Library at UC San Diego (1969–70), "a fascinating nexus between brutalism and futurism" — intended in steel and glass until cost moved the structure outside.

Robarts Library, Toronto (Warner, Burns, Toan and Lunde, 1968–73), condemned on opening as "a blunder on the grandest scale".

STILL CLOSED — The UEA ziggurats closed in 2023 in the reinforced autoclaved aerated concrete crisis, with no refurbishment date set as of February 2025.

117 metres of Belgrade

11

The Western City Gate — also known as the Genex Tower — in Belgrade, Serbia.

36	117	1977
STOREYS	METRES · 384 FT	MIHAJLO MITROVIĆ

Formed by two towers connected with a two-storey bridge, with a revolving restaurant at the top. With the restaurant it reaches 135–140 m (443–459 ft).

Considered a prime representative of the style in Serbia, and one of the best built anywhere in the 1960s and 1970s.

NO DATA

The source calls the Genex Tower the second-tallest high-rise in Belgrade, after Ušće Tower — but gives no height for it. The gap is printed, not estimated.

The public verdict

12

> Few styles in history can have been met with so many pleas from its users to see it destroyed.
>
> — SIMON JENKINS

A 2014 article in The Economist noted that a campaign to demolish a building will usually be directed against a brutalist one.

8

In 2005 the British TV programme *Demolition* ran a public vote to select twelve buildings that ought to be demolished — eight of those selected were brutalist.

Concrete façades do not age well in damp maritime climates: water stains, moss and lichen, rust from the reinforcing bars. Critics add the "cold" look and an air of totalitarianism.



The Queen Elizabeth Square flats in Glasgow (1962) were demolished in 1993.

The score sheet

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BUILDING	ARCHITECT	YEAR	OUTCOME
DEMOLISHED			
Tricorn Centre, Portsmouth	Owen Luder and Rodney Gordon	2004	Demolished
Third Church of Christ, Scientist, D.C.	Araldo Cossutta	2014	Demolished
Birmingham Central Library	John Madin	2016	Demolished
Robin Hood Gardens, East London	Alison and Peter Smithson	2017	Demolished
Welbeck Street car park, London	NO DATA	2019	Demolished
American Press Institute, Reston VA	Marcel Breuer	NO DATA	Demolished
SAVED OR LISTED			
Villa Göth, Uppsala	Bengt Edman and Lennart Holm	1995	Listed by Uppsala county
Preston bus station garage	NO DATA	2013	Grade II listed
Dunelm House, Durham	Architects' Co-Partnership	2021	Saved, 5-year campaign
Southbank Centre, London	NO DATA	2026	Grade II listed

The Twentieth Century Society lost the Tricorn and Trinity Square, and won Preston and the Southbank.

Printed back into fashion

14

THE REVIVAL IN PRINT

BRUTAL LONDON · Zupagrafika, 2015

BRUTALIST LONDON MAP · 2015

THIS BRUTAL WORLD · 2016

SOS BRUTALISM: A GLOBAL SURVEY · 2017

ATLAS OF BRUTALIST ARCHITECTURE · 2018

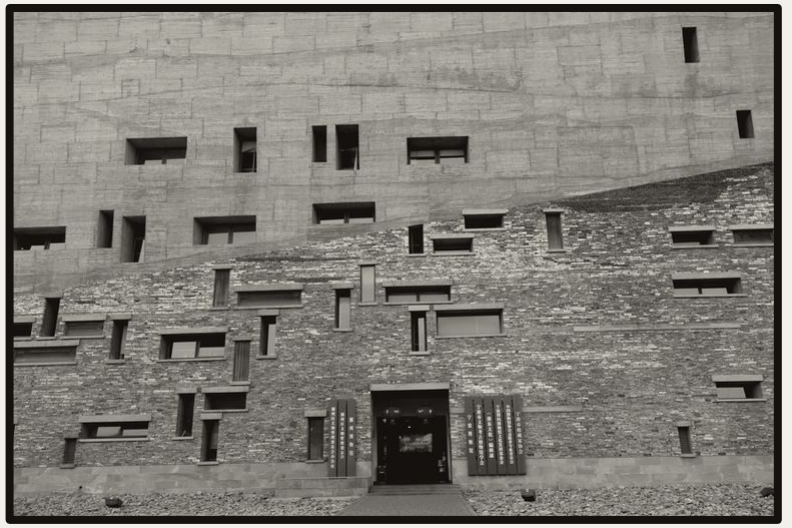
The original movement was largely over by the late 1970s and early 1980s, having given way to structural expressionism and deconstructivism. Interest resurged from 2015, and new construction followed, termed neobrutalism.

Neobrutalist buildings tend to be commissioned by the private sector, and may use recycled brick or timber rather than concrete — while still exposing materials and structure.

BUILT AGAIN

Wang Shu's Ningbo Museum (2008) shows traces of the bamboo framework on its monumental concrete, called "an urban icon" in his 2012 Pritzker Prize citation.

The campus of the private University of Engineering and Technology (UTEC) in Peru, by Yvonne Farrell and Shelley McNamara, is referenced in their 2020 Pritzker citation.



© Siyuwj, building designed by Wang Shu / Wikimedia Commons / CC BY-SA 3.0

Many defining aspects have been softened: façades sandblasted to a stone-like surface, covered in stucco, or made of patterned precast elements — as in the redevelopment of Sheffield's Park Hill. But board-marked concrete is still used, as at the neobrutalist Silberrad Student Centre, University of Essex (2015).

Honest to the end

15

Judge it the way it asked to be judged

AN ETHIC, NOT AN AESTHETIC

FORMAL LEGIBILITY OF PLAN · CLEAR EXHIBITION OF STRUCTURE · MATERIALS AS FOUND

The style has been polarising throughout its history — public campaigns to demolish brutalist buildings are common, and in the United Kingdom some have been preserved.

Source

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